

Scorched Earth

Widow's Bight, 1940s — alternate draft: total denial

His mother had named him Ekon because she wanted a word in her son's mouth the world would have to reckon with before it got around to insulting him, and Ekon Freeman had spent forty-one years finding out exactly how little a name buys a man on its own, and rather more about what paper does to a man once somebody else's hand is holding the pen. He had watched a town clerk write *transients* next to his mother's name and his brother's and understood, long before he had the words for it, that a document was never neutral ground. It was a weapon like any other, and like any other weapon it pointed wherever the hand behind it chose to aim.

He had gone to war and come back exactly as capable as the Army had spent three years teaching him to be, and he intended, for once in his family's dealings with this town, to use every bit of that competence on something that would actually hold still and be solved. What he no longer entirely trusted, coming home, was the idea that solving a thing and writing it down were the same act, or that a record — however true — was ever safe simply because it was true.

[MATCHES: 24]

The lawyer's office smelled like a man who did not open his windows on principle. Adrian Voss had represented Ekon's mother in her last years, badly and half-heartedly, and had not destroyed a single document she'd left in his keeping only because destroying documents was a specific kind of trouble a careful man avoided, not because he had ever once intended to use them for her.

"The lay," Voss said, turning the word over like a coin he wasn't sure was real currency anymore. "Wages owed a dead whaler off a ship that hasn't existed in a hundred-odd years. You understand there's no court in this county that opens that book again."

"I understand you're still holding the book," Ekon said. "That's the part I came about."

Voss gave it to him in the end — not out of conscience, Ekon was fairly sure, but because handing over a folder cost him nothing and refusing might eventually cost him something. Ekon read it standing in the man's doorway: his ancestor's name, a ship's name, a sum, a lay percentage promised and never once paid, his mother's own hand in the margin where she'd

once tried and failed to make her case to somebody who'd stopped listening before she finished the sentence.

It proved everything and changed nothing, exactly as he'd expected walking in. He folded it and put it inside his coat anyway, and thought, not for the first time, that a fact written down and a fact honored were two entirely different animals, and that this county had spent a hundred years demonstrating it knew the difference perfectly well and simply preferred the first one, because the first one cost nothing to keep filed away and forgotten.

Voss was already turning back to his own desk when he stopped, opened a lower drawer with the particular reluctance of a man remembering an obligation he'd hoped had lapsed, and set a second folder on the blotter — thinner, older, water-stained along one edge.

"This isn't yours to claim, and I couldn't tell you how it ended up in with your mother's papers if you asked me twice," Voss said. He did not offer to try a third time. "Take it if you want it. One less thing in my drawer."

Ekon did not know the name on the cover — *W. CORWIN, OFFICER, PRECINCT 4* — and had no reason to. He opened it anyway and read a stranger's cramped, deliberately legible hand recording six men in a rose garden and, beneath them, two more the town's history had never agreed to count: a woman, a boy, and a single stubborn digit — *eight* — written where every official version he'd ever encountered insisted on six.

He stood there a long moment, and what he felt was not quite the kinship a kinder man might have felt. It was something closer to a cold, private confirmation of a thing he already suspected: a true number, written down honestly, by a man willing to put his own hand to it, had sat in a drawer for twenty years and changed exactly nothing. The paper had survived. The two people it was written for had not, and neither had the man who'd insisted on writing it. He put the file in his coat beside the wage claim, both folded the same careful way, and did not, on the walk out, feel especially reassured by the company they kept there.

[MATCHES: 23]

The ruins on the drowned island were exactly the kind of ground the Army had trained him for and exactly the kind of ground nothing in his training had prepared him to want to enter twice. He moved through the collapsed sections with the flat, economical caution of a man who has already learned what happens to careless men in unstable structures, testing weight before trusting it. When a support beam gave under him in the second gallery and dropped him eight feet onto broken masonry, he took the fall the way he'd been trained to take falls, rolled it out, came up with a cracked rib and nothing worse, and kept moving inside the hour.

An old man met him at the mouth of the third gallery, standing where the light gave out — grayscale to the collar, a single ring catching color no lantern down here had any business giving it — and beside him a man perhaps forty, moving with the specific unhurried economy of someone who'd learned his trade from exactly this teacher and no one else.

"You've come further than most who carry a rifle instead of a trowel," the old man said.

"I'm not digging," Ekon said. "I'm finishing something."

"There was another one, years back. Carried a trowel instead of a rifle. Went further than we go, same as you're about to. He never came back up either." The old man considered Ekon a while longer than the question warranted. "You carry papers in that coat. I can see the shape of them from here."

"Proof of a debt this town's owed my family for a hundred years."

"Proof's a heavy thing to carry into a place like this," the old man said. "Heavier than most men realize, until they're the ones asked to set it down." He said nothing further, and the younger man beside him only watched Ekon's hands the way a man watches another man's hands when he is deciding, privately, whether they belong to someone competent. Ekon understood, without being told, that he had just been measured by the same standard the old man had once used on the boy now standing beside him, and had — he could not have said how he knew, only that he knew — been found adequate.

He met exactly one hazard in those first galleries that a rifle solved cleanly — something that had once been a man and no longer troubled itself with the distinction, coming at him out of a side passage with the loose, wet-jointed hurry of a thing that had forgotten what its own body was for. He put three rounds into it with the flat unhesitating competence of a man who had done this before, and it went down and stayed down, and he felt, for one clean, uncomplicated moment, like a man finally facing a problem his training had actual jurisdiction over.

[MATCHES: 21]

He was, for a little while, allowed to believe that.

Deeper in, past a threshold his own map called the end of any reasonable itinerary, he came on a second one of the same general shape, and shot it the same clean way — three rounds, center mass — and watched it stagger and keep coming regardless, indifferent to the wound the way a filed report is indifferent to the truth it's supposed to be carrying. He gave it ground rather than press the issue, and it did not pursue him past the gallery's threshold. He understood, retreating, that the first thing he'd killed and the second thing he'd only staggered had looked, to

an untrained eye, like the same category of trouble, and were not — one answered to force the way a fact answers to a competent hand; the other simply absorbed whatever was spent on it and went on regardless, the way this town's official record had always gone on regardless of how true or how documented the version underneath it happened to be.

[MATCHES: 18]

He found the book two nights before the end, wedged with a stack of a dead predecessor's field notes in a niche no team roster listed anyone having reached before him. Beside it, a corroded field notebook, swollen shut with damp, and the long-settled shape of what had once, a decade or so back by the state of it, been a man about his own age.

He sat with the stranger a while before he touched anything. The notebook, once he worked it open, was a stranger's obsessive, meticulous catalog of a season's finds, entries running clean and rigorous for a hundred pages and then, toward the end, running into numbers that skipped and doubled back on themselves. Ekon had no way of knowing the name Ward Kohistani, would never know it, and understood anyway, reading that ledger start to finish in the bad light of a match he was rationing, that whoever this had been had died doing careful, honest work.

"You did the job," he said aloud, to a dead stranger who couldn't hear him, and meant it. He meant, too, though he did not say this part aloud, that the job had cost the man everything and paid him back nothing anyone living had ever come to collect — and that a ledger this careful, sitting unread in the dark for a decade, was proof of exactly the same thing the file in his coat was proof of. Diligence did not protect a record. It only made the record more complete at the moment nobody came for it.

[MATCHES: 15]

The book beside the ledger held two hands of marginal notes he didn't yet know belonged to two different men in two different decades. Ekon read the passage they'd both underlined — a plain scholarly account of a minor figure from old Greek cosmogony, half-remembered and mostly discredited — and felt something in the base of his skull go very cold, because he had heard that name before, carved into stonework in a private club on the mainland, and in a business name over on the Ophion Trust building, where a rich man's family had named their fortune after the very thing that had made it.

Nobody in the game he was playing was going to say it out loud for him. He understood it anyway, in the same silent, arriving way you understand a formation is about to be overrun a half-second before the order comes down.

The gallery beyond the drowned man's chamber opened onto a stretch of cavern that stopped behaving like a cavern should. There was a stretch of narrow passage a patient man could take without ever announcing himself, and he took it the patient way, closing the distance on his own terms rather than the ground's. It bought him a clean approach on the last of the man-shaped things between him and the abyss's mouth, and he put it down without ceremony, three rounds, the same flat competence as before.

[MATCHES: 11]

Then the passage ended in a drop no rope he carried was long enough for, into a dark his lantern could not find the bottom of, and something down there looked back up at him — not hunting, not hostile, simply present — and every ounce of trained competence he had walked in with sat in his hands and did precisely nothing.

His training did not abandon him. It simply changed subject. He couldn't kill what was down there. He could deny it ground. He found the charges he'd carried in for exactly this kind of collapse-and-seal contingency, set them along the passage's weakest span, and understood with total clarity that he was not fighting anymore so much as retreating with intent.

[MATCHES: 4]

He went down anyway, before he lit the fuse, because some part of him needed to look the thing in whatever passed for its face before he did the one thing left to do about it.

What he found down there did not resolve into an answer his eyes were built to hold. It was not the mother-shape that had unmade Walter Corwin. It simply was, entire and unbroken and entirely without interest in whether Ekon understood any part of it, and understanding arrived in him whole and immediate and did not kill him outright, only because there was, by then, almost nothing left of the passage between them for it to travel through before the charges did their work.

[MATCHES: 1]

He had one clear-headed moment left, the only such moment either of his predecessors had ever been granted and neither had lived lucid enough to use. He had, in his coat, four things: the wage claim, proven and uncollectable; a dead stranger's honest, complete ledger; a dead officer's file with its stubborn, uncounted eight; and the fuse in his other hand.

He thought of his mother, who had carried proof of a debt for years and died with it still unhonored. He thought of a cop who had written a true number in a hand deliberately made

larger than the rest, and had it filed, forgotten, and finally handed across a lawyer's desk to a stranger by accident, twenty years too late to matter to anyone it was written for. He thought of a man who had spent a season cataloguing a ruin with total, honest rigor, and left behind a book no one had opened until Ekon pried it loose from beside his bones. Three men, three records, each one true, each one complete, each one utterly unable to do the one thing a record is supposed to do, which is matter to somebody while it still could.

He understood, in that last clear second, a colder version of what his mother and a dead cop and a dead stranger had never quite let themselves conclude: that a true thing written down was not the same as a true thing kept. That paper survived the people it concerned and helped none of them. That the town did not need to burn a record to erase it — it only needed to leave it exactly where it was, correctly filed, perfectly true, and utterly unread, the way it had already done to two of the three folders now sitting against his chest.

He did not choose which of it to send home. He chose, instead, to let none of it outlive him in a form this town could go on ignoring at its leisure. He fed the wage claim into the same fire that would take him, and the ledger after it, and the cop's file last of all, watching the number eight curl and blacken along with everything else, and felt no grief in the doing that surprised him — only the specific, unsentimental clarity of a soldier denying an enemy anything at all to make use of, applied, for once, to his own family's proof and two strangers' life work in the same motion. Better that nothing survived than that something survived exactly the way it always had: correctly, patiently, uselessly, in a drawer nobody with the power to act on it would ever think to open.

He struck his last match — not to read anything by, not one final time, but only because he needed the light to set the fuse cleanly, and there was, by then, nothing left in his coat worth seeing by it anyway.

[MATCHES: 0]

He lit the fuse.

The film stock does not fail so much as it refuses. It burns, curls, and dissolves along its own edges, the emulsion giving up frame by frame the way paper gives up to flame, because whatever the lens has been asked to hold is larger than the stock's willingness to keep holding it.

The camera does not linger to watch the rest. It pulls back — through collapsing rock, through packed earth that should stop a lens as surely as it stops a man, up and away and out — and settles, at the very last, on the Ophion estate's manicured lawn above, green and tended and entirely, permanently unaware that anything at all had ever happened beneath it.

Nothing waits on the ground above this time. No folded document proves a claim to nobody. No ledger survives to validate a dead stranger's work. No stubborn digit sits in a drawer for some future reader to stumble on by accident. Whatever the town would have gone on ignoring, correctly filed and perfectly true, simply isn't there anymore for it to ignore — and whether that counts as a victory or the last and coldest thing this family lost was never a question the fire was built to answer either way.

END OF CHAPTER THREE — ALTERNATE DRAFT